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Nai Roga

Weekly Message **Saptahik Samachar**

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To all members of Fiji National University

Bula! The highlight of last week was the official visit of the Australian Prime Minister, Scott Morrison, and his Assistant Minister for International Development and the Pacific, Anne Rushton, to our Derrick Campus. His focus was on the University's deepening partnership with the Australia Pacific Training Coalition (APTC), formerly the Australia Pacific Training College. Prime Minister Morrison visited students studying refrigeration and air-conditioning in a joint FNU-APTC facility and was briefed on the University's plans to relocate more of APTC's training facilities to the Derrick Campus in the coming months.

When the APTC initiative was launched in 2007 as the Australia Pacific Training College, its primary goal was to establish training centres across the region – sometimes in partnership with local providers, but often freestanding – which delivered Australian technical and vocational education and training (TVET) programmes through TAFE Queensland. These programmes ranged from Certificate III to Diplomas. The primary aim was to train Pacific Islanders to Australian standards, so that they could move to Australia and take up jobs in areas of skill shortage.

When I first met with colleagues from the APTC in August 2016, I could immediately see the benefits to Australia (in the form of scarce skilled workers) and the APTC's students (increased earnings in Australia and the prospect of permanent migration), but I could not see the advantage of a partnership between FNU and APTC. As Fiji's national university, our role is to educate and train students to meet our national employment needs, so that our best and brightest young people stay in Fiji to contribute the country's economic development – not upskill them so that they can migrate to Australia.

Nevertheless, we maintained a close and cooperative relationship with APTC and contributed to the consultations that took place across the Pacific in 2017 to inform the third phase of the project. In August 2018, the (then) Australian Minister for Foreign Affairs, Julie Bishop, announced the launch of the third phase, rebranding APTC as the Australia Pacific Training Coalition and shifting the focus to building deep partnerships with local partners, so that there would be a sustainable legacy when the project comes to an end.

The aim is that, by embedding APTC training facilities in local providers and supporting the development of their teaching staff, the local providers will be able to gradually take over running the APTC programmes to an Australian standard. FNU and APTC have recently signed a Memorandum of Understanding, with the aim of APTC relocating its training centres to FNU, mainly on our Derrick Campus. APTC will initially teach their students alongside those taking FNU programmes, but we will progressively work together to harmonise the programmes. The end goal is for FNU to be offer our own programmes which are accredited by TAFE Queensland, either as joint programmes or with some other form of dual branding.

Further away from home, I spent part of last week chairing an institutional accreditation panel for the Hong Kong government. Hong Kong has a sophisticated system of academic quality assurance and regularly uses foreign experts to ensure that the standards of its programmes and institutions are at an international level. I was involved in the review of programmes in the area of decision science, big data analytics and artificial intelligence. The so-called 'Industrial Revolution 4.0' (cyber-physical systems, the 'internet of things', cloud computing) is a hot topic, but it was fascinating to see first-hand the way these trends are impacting on one of the Hong Kong universities' syllabus.

One of the most memorable parts of the review was a visit to the university's virtual reality (VR) facility. My view for some years has been that the highest-profile developments in digitally-enhanced learning so far, notably so-called 'massive open online course' (MOOCs) which were supposed to replace face-to-face teaching and wipe out most universities, have been overhyped. However, I have always felt that gamification and VR could be game-changers, because they allow universities to simulate learning environments that would be impossible for students to experience in the real world.

Having (virtually) walked through the baggage handling facilities at Chek Lap Kok Airport in Hong Kong and seen first-hand how students can experience managing a world-class logistics centre in an immersive, virtual environment, I am more convinced than ever. Our partnership with the Indian Centre for the Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC), which is funding the India-Fiji Centre of Excellence in Information Technology at the Derrick Campus, holds out the possibility that we can also begin to explore the potential for such learning technologies here in Fiji.

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